

Rahman's UNIVERSE

The musician is so tenacious about his privacy that for every story about him, there is another. A glimpse into his restricted world.

The KM Music Conservatory



STUDENTS AT THE KM MUSIC CONSERVATORY

Full-time foundation and part-time preparatory courses train youngsters in music. Three of the 40 full-timers who pay Rs 2.5 lakh each have already been signed on to

apprentice with Rahman. "Investing in education is the best thing ever," says Rahman.

The AM Studio

A high-tech studio where everyone from John McLaughlin to Vishal Shekhar (for *Om Shanti Om* and *Aaja Nachle*) have recorded. The phenomenally well-equipped studio is named after his Sufi guru.

H.K. RAJASHEKAR



THE NEVE 88R AT RAHMAN'S AM STUDIO

Publishing Rights

Rahman tries to retain the publishing rights of his music wherever possible so he can reuse it free of cost. His fee for a soundtrack is usually Rs 2 crore.

Endorsements

He is the face of Airtel, has represented Worldspace for a year, and has a strategic partnership with Nokia. Global concerts are organised by long time promoter Deepak Gattani. The last one was in 2007.

GETTY IMAGES



RAHMAN WITH *SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE*'S DIRECTOR DANNY BOYLE (CENTRE) AND SCREENPLAY WRITER SIMON BEAUFOY AT THE GOLDEN GLOBES

“What brought success to *Slumdog Millionaire* is its uniqueness and originality. When everyone else was doing something, another culture got introduced.”

ments of doubt though and it's then that Rahman heads off to Andhra Pradesh to meet his spiritual guru, Arifa Malik. "It's good to talk to someone who is disconnected from all this. Who shares good things with the world," he says. It's probably the same urge that sees him dashing off to the nearest dargah in Chennai. "He has earmarked a few across the city," says Selvakumar, "depending on where he is."

He is his own worst critic. As he says: "I need to approve my own work. You can go wrong even then. You have to keep an open mind and take inputs. Often you don't have time." Like the master of *Slumdog Millionaire*. They were mixing it and literally uploading straight on to the Internet for the US release to meet the two week Oscar deadline. "We worked 20 hours for three days, sleeping for just two hours. In fact we even got a lot of abuse from the US guys. But yesterday it's No. 1 in the US digital downloads. Whenever there is too much trauma, bad pressure, it always pays off," says Rahman. But he is firm that music should bring a positive vibe to the listeners. "People should feel uplifted." He is an astute businessman as well, insisting wherever possible that he retain publishing rights to his songs. He is the face of Airtel, for a reported contract of Rs 1 crore every year, has a strategic partnership with Nokia for projects with a common vision and also popped up as a celebrity judge on 9X's *Mission Ustaad* last year.

As he signs papers close to midnight in a day where he has done 20 interviews, back to back, he talks of being introduced at a Los Angeles party to all the music heads of the big Hollywood studios. "They were all familiar with my music," he says, with just a tinge of surprise. And then he adds with typical understatement: "Offers could come." They always do.